

KHALISTAN

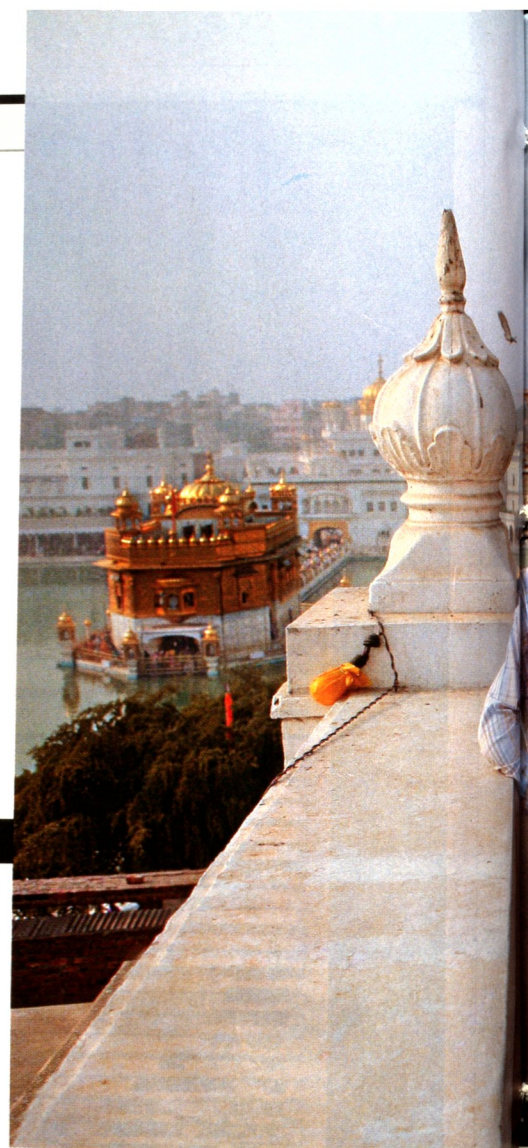
A Lost CAUSE

It claimed 25,000 lives and cost Punjab Rs 13,000 crore over two decades. Militancy in the state may be on the wane, but its terrible memories refuse to go away.

Crackdown in Punjab

No decision could have been more painful, more fraught with tragic consequences, than the one to launch Operation Bluestar. And yet, it was a denouement that was somehow inevitable. For close to three bloody years, Mrs Gandhi's government had dithered and dallied as the extremist threat emanating from the Golden Temple, the most sacred symbol of Sikhism and the seat of its religious power, had acquired monstrous proportions. From here, hit-lists had been cold-bloodedly drawn up and death squads dispatched to wreak their deadly havoc—all master-minded by the malevolent figure of Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale. For three long years, the chanting of the gurbani had been punctuated by the staccato bursts of gunfire as the extremists carried out summary executions or exchanged fire with security forces. And now, pushed to the wall, Mrs Gandhi finally did what few could deny had to be done: the biggest and most significant counter terrorist action undertaken anywhere in the world.

Shekhar Gupta, June 30, 1984, INDIA TODAY



■ By Ramesh Vinayak

It was early morning on January 1, 1988, when my telephone rang. It was a policeman with information: terrorists had struck at Cheema Batth, a village in Amritsar district. After an hour-long drive, I reached the farmhouse where gun shots had rung out the night before. Through the half-open door, I saw nine blood-splattered bodies on the floor. Not a soul was left to mourn as the whole family, including a four-month old child, were killed by a terrorist gang on the suspicion that they were police informers.

Two decades later, Cheema Batth is still haunting us. Much like the '80s, when massacres were as common as marriages with more than 25,000 lives lost, including that of a prime minister. Statistics don't do justice to the firestorm that swept Punjab in the name of the pro-secessionist Khalistan movement. What began as a non-violent political protest for greater autonomy in the mid-'70s, spiralled into a cycle of violence, fuelled by political chicanery, Sikh